

Family History Research Interview

For this family history interview, I interviewed my grandmother, who was born in Huehuetenango, Guatemala, but eventually moved to Quetzaltenango, where our family currently lives. I chose to interview her because her experiences helped me understand how our family came to live in Quetzaltenango and the challenges and values that shaped the generations that followed.

According to my grandmother, she always enjoyed studying, and she once received a scholarship to attend the Instituto Nacional de Señoritas de Occidente (INSO) in Quetzaltenango. However, her father did not allow her to accept the scholarship because she would have needed to leave Huehuetenango and live in Quetzaltenango. Instead of giving up on her goals, she left her parents' home and moved to Quetzaltenango to work with an aunt. Later, she accompanied one of her cousins who came to study there. During that time, she had several jobs and eventually met my grandfather, who rented a place in the same house where she and her cousin lived. Their relationship developed gradually, and after some time, they eventually married.

One of the greatest challenges my grandmother's family faced was providing educational opportunities for her children despite financial difficulties. When my grandmother explained that her husband would only provide basic education and that her daughters would need to work if they wanted professional careers, I understood how important education was to her. She worked to help pay for her children's education and used part of the money available to support their studies. Her efforts, combined with the work and determination of her daughters and the scholarships they received, helped them continue their education. My mother, for example, graduated as a doctor with the help of a scholarship.

My grandmother also emphasized that faith, hope, effort, courage, loyalty, and responsibility helped the family overcome difficulties. She remembers traditions such as preparing honey and bread during Holy Week and visiting the cemetery on November 1 to remember deceased family members. Most importantly, she advised future generations, stating, "No matter where you come from, you can always improve and change your story. It all depends on you." This interview helped me see how my family's history connects with my Personal History Project because my grandmother's experiences show me that our past can influence us, but it does not have to determine our future.

Reference

Samayoa Lopez, Ofelia Felipa. (2026, July 20). Personal interview